

Comprehensive List of Common OTC Medicines

Includes purpose, dosage, symptoms treated, contraindications, and other features.

Name	Category	Purpose	Dosage	Symptoms	Contraindications	Other Features
Paracetamol (Acetaminophen)	Analgesic / Antipyretic	Pain relief, fever reduction	500–1000 mg every 4–6 hrs (max 4 g/24 hrs)	Headache, fever, muscle aches, toothache	Severe liver disease; avoid with other paracetamol-containing products; caution with alcohol use	Safe in pregnancy at recommended doses; widely available in many brand names
Ibuprofen	NSAID (Analgesic/Anti-inflammatory)	Pain, inflammation, fever	200–400 mg every 4–6 hrs (usual OTC max 1200 mg/24 hrs without doctor)	Muscle pain, menstrual cramps, dental pain, fever	Active peptic ulcer/bleeding, severe heart failure, severe kidney disease, NSAID allergy, pregnancy (third trimester)	Take with food to reduce GI upset; interacts with anticoagulants
Aspirin (Acetylsalicylic acid)	NSAID / Antiplatelet	Pain relief, fever, anti-inflammatory; low-dose used for cardiac prevention (under medical advice)	325–1000 mg every 4–6 hrs as needed (do not exceed label guidance); low-dose 75–100 mg for CV prevention only if advised	Headache, musculoskeletal pain, fever	Children/teens with viral illness (risk of Reye's syndrome), bleeding disorders, active peptic ulcer, aspirin allergy, pregnancy (third trimester)	Not recommended for viral-fever in children
Cetirizine	Second-generation antihistamine	Allergic rhinitis, urticaria (hives)	10 mg once daily	Sneezing, itchy/watery eyes, runny nose, hives	Severe kidney impairment (dose adjust), caution with sedation when combined with alcohol or CNS depressants	Less sedating than first-generation antihistamines
Loratadine	Second-generation antihistamine	Allergic rhinitis, hives	10 mg once daily	Allergy symptoms: sneezing, runny nose, itchy eyes, hives	Severe liver impairment (dose adjust), caution with some antifungals/antibiotics	Non-sedating at usual doses
Diphenhydramine	First-generation antihistamine / Sleep aid	Allergy relief, short-term insomnia, motion sickness	25–50 mg every 4–6 hrs (max ~300 mg/24 hrs depending on product)	Itchy eyes, sneezing, runny nose, allergic reactions, short-term insomnia	Elderly (falls, confusion), glaucoma, urinary retention, severe asthma; avoid with other sedatives or alcohol	Causes marked drowsiness; used as OTC sleep aid in many countries
Pseudoephedrine (behind-the-counter in many countries)	Oral decongestant	Nasal/sinus congestion relief	60 mg every 4–6 hrs (max 240 mg/24 hrs) depending on formulation	Nasal congestion with colds/allergies	Uncontrolled hypertension, severe coronary artery disease, hyperthyroidism, MAOI use	Often regulated due to misuse in illicit drug manufacture
Phenylephrine (oral)	Oral decongestant	Temporary relief of nasal congestion (effectiveness under review)	10 mg every 4 hrs (many products)	Nasal congestion	Severe hypertension, severe coronary disease, MAOI use; note: FDA has questioned oral effectiveness	Nasal-spray phenylephrine still used topically
Dextromethorphan	Cough suppressant (antitussive)	Temporary relief of cough	10–20 mg every 4 hrs or 30 mg every 6–8 hrs (max 120 mg/24 hrs)	Dry, non-productive cough	Concurrent MAOI use, caution with serotonergic drugs (risk serotonin syndrome in combinations/overdose), misuse/abuse potential at high doses	Common in many OTC cough medicines; avoid in children under recommended ages
Guaifenesin	Expectorant	Loosens mucus in chest, helps clear productive cough	200–400 mg every 4 hrs (max about 2.4 g/24 hrs depending on product)	Productive cough with mucus	Generally well tolerated; check for combination products and other active ingredients	Hydration helps its effect

Loperamide	Antidiarrheal	Reduce diarrhoea frequency	4 mg initially then 2 mg after each loose stool (max 8 mg OTC or 16 mg under medical advice depending on local labelling)	Acute non-bloody diarrhoea	Bloody diarrhoea or fever (may indicate infection), children under certain ages, severe hepatic impairment (dose adjust), suspected C. difficile infection	Not for long-term use without medical advice
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Name	Category	Purpose	Dosage	Symptoms	Contraindications	Other Features
Bismuth subsalicylate (Pepto-Bismol)	Antacid/antidiarrheal/anti-nausea	Relieves upset stomach, diarrhoea, heartburn, nausea	525 mg (1 tablespoon or 30 mL liquid) every 30–60 mins as needed (max ~8 doses/24 hrs depending on product)	Indigestion, nausea, diarrhoea, heartburn	Children/teens with viral illness (contains salicylate — Reye's risk), aspirin allergy, severe kidney disease	May darken tongue/stool; contains salicylate
Omeprazole (OTC PPI)	Proton pump inhibitor (acid reducer)	Short-term treatment of frequent heartburn	20 mg once daily for 14 days (OTC course) unless advised otherwise	Frequent heartburn (>2 days/week)	Known allergy to PPIs; long-term PPI use requires medical review due to risks (B12 deficiency, bone fractures, infections)	Not for immediate relief of acute heartburn; used as 14-day course
Famotidine (OTC H2 blocker)	H2 receptor antagonist (acid reducer)	Heartburn relief and prevention	10–20 mg up to twice daily depending on product	Heartburn, acid indigestion	Severe renal impairment (dose adjust), allergy to H2 blockers	Faster onset than PPI for some
Antacids (Calcium carbonate, Magnesium hydroxide, Aluminum hydroxide)	Antacid	Neutralize stomach acid for quick relief	Follow label; calcium carbonate often 500–1500 mg as needed up to label max	Heartburn, indigestion, sour stomach	Severe kidney disease (magnesium/aluminum accumulation), calcium restriction conditions; interactions with absorption of some drugs	Fast onset but short duration
Laxatives - Polyethylene glycol (PEG 3350)	Osmotic laxative	Relieve occasional constipation	17 g dissolved in 4–8 oz water once daily (typical OTC), follow label	Constipation	Intestinal obstruction, severe abdominal pain of unknown cause	Works in 1–3 days; safe for short-term use
Laxatives - Senna / Bisacodyl (Stimulant laxatives)	Stimulant laxative	Relieve constipation	Senna: 12–30 mg at bedtime; Bisacodyl: 5–15 mg oral once daily	Constipation	Intestinal obstruction, acute abdominal pain, nausea/vomiting, inflammatory bowel disease	Use short-term; avoid long-term dependence
Docusate sodium (stool softener)	Emollient laxative	Soften stool to relieve constipation	100 mg once or twice daily (product labels vary)	Constipation, hard stools	Intestinal obstruction, abdominal pain, nausea/vomiting	Often used when straining should be avoided (post-surgery)
Meclizine / Dimenhydrinate	Antiemetic / Antihistamine (motion sickness)	Prevent/treat motion sickness, vertigo	Meclizine 25–50 mg once daily; Dimenhydrinate 50–100 mg every 4–6 hrs as needed (follow label)	Nausea, vomiting, dizziness from motion	Glaucoma (angle-closure), severe respiratory depression, caution in elderly	Causes drowsiness; avoid driving if affected
Hydrocortisone 1% (topical)	Low-potency topical steroid	Reduce inflammation/itching for eczema, dermatitis, insect bites	Apply thin layer 1–4 times daily as needed (follow label)	Itchy rash, eczema flare, insect bites	Skin infection at application site (unless combined with anti-infective), use on face/underarms/genitals with caution; avoid prolonged use	OTC for short-term local use
Clotrimazole / Miconazole (topical antifungals)	Antifungal (topical)	Treat athlete's foot, ringworm, vaginal thrush (some formulations)	Apply as directed (often once or twice daily for 2–4 weeks)	Itchy/red rash in fungal infections, vaginal discharge for thrush	Allergy to azole antifungals	Many OTC formulations available
Terbinafine (topical)	Antifungal (topical)	Treat athlete's foot and ringworm	Apply once or twice daily as per product (commonly 1% cream)	Fungal skin infections	Allergy to terbinafine	Oral terbinafine for nail fungus is prescription-only

Name	Category	Purpose	Dosage	Symptoms	Contraindications	Other Features
Topical antibiotic ointments (Neomycin/Bacitracin/Poly myxin B)	Topical antibiotic	Prevent infection in minor cuts/scrapes	Apply small amount to wound 1–3 times daily	Minor wound care	Allergy to ingredients (contact dermatitis possible)	Some people allergic to neomycin; avoid overuse
Neosporin-type triple antibiotic (bacitracin + neomycin + polymyxin B)	Topical antibiotic	Prevent minor wound infection	Apply thin layer to wound 1–3 times daily	Cuts, scrapes	Allergic reactions to components	May cause contact dermatitis in some individuals
Hydrogen peroxide / Povidone-iodine	Topical antiseptic	Clean minor wounds to reduce infection risk	Use as directed; povidone-iodine often applied once; hydrogen peroxide for initial cleaning then avoid repeated use	Minor cuts, abrasions	Deep puncture wounds, serious burns, animal bites (seek medical care)	Povidone-iodine may stain; use per instructions
Docosanol (Abreva)	Topical antiviral	Reduce duration/severity of cold sores (herpes labialis)	Apply at first sign of outbreak 5 times daily until healed (per product)	Cold sore / fever blister	Allergy to ingredients	Most effective when started early
Skin barrier / antifungal powders (Tolnaftate)	Antifungal powder	Prevent/treat athlete's foot and chafing	Use as directed (dry area before applying)	Fungal skin infections, chafing	Allergy	
Sunscreen (SPF products)	Topical UV protection	Protect skin from UV radiation (prevent burns and long-term damage)	Apply liberally 15 mins before sun exposure; reapply every 2 hours or after swimming/sweating	Sunburn prevention	Allergy to components	Use broad-spectrum SPF 30+ recommended by many health bodies
Nicotine replacement (gum/ patch/lozenge)	Smoking cessation aid	Help quit smoking by reducing withdrawal	Patch/ gum dosing varies by dependence level; follow product instructions	Nicotine withdrawal cravings	Recent myocardial infarction (consult doctor), severe arrhythmia (medical advice)	OTC forms available; higher-strength/combination therapy may be prescription-guided
Topical diclofenac gel (e.g., 1% or 2%)	Topical NSAID	Local pain relief for osteoarthritis joints, muscle pain	Apply to affected area 3–4 times daily as per product label	Localized joint/muscle pain	Allergy to diclofenac/NSAIDs, application to broken skin, avoid on large areas long-term	Systemic absorption minimal but caution if taking oral NSAIDs